THE HOUSE OF IDEAS

CHAPTER SIX

“WERE YOU IN MY MOVIE?”

February 19 – June 16, 2008
New York & Los Angeles

An Alternate-History Hollywood Saga

COLD OPEN

INT. A DIVE BAR - LOWER EAST SIDE, NEW YORK CITY - NIGHT (FLASHBACK)

SUPER: FOUR MONTHS EARLIER - TUESDAY, FEBRUARY 19, 2008 - 2:14 A.M. EST

A real dive bar on Ludlow Street, rented for one night and closed to the public. Neon beer signs. A sticky jukebox. Just eleven crew members, every one of them under a nondisclosure agreement so strict it lists penalties in six figures.

WILLIAM HURT (57), as General "Thunderbolt" Ross, sits at the bar with a glass of whiskey. In the doorway, in a sharp suit and sunglasses at two in the morning, MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK (26).

KEVIN FEIGE (34) and LOUIS LETERRIER (34) huddle behind a single monitor, whispering.

LETERRIER
Nobody knows. Not Universal marketing. Not the trailer house. Not even the editor's assistant. We cut this scene in a locked room in Burbank and the drive goes in Kevin's safe.

FEIGE
And Amond?

LETERRIER
(a long, pained sigh)
Kevin. I love Amond. Amond is a beautiful soul. Amond told a barista in Harlem about the gray Hulk. Amond cannot know.

FEIGE
Agreed. He finds out with everybody else.

LETERRIER
He will kill us.

FEIGE
He'll forgive us. He's Bruce Banner. He's very gentle.

LETERRIER
Until he isn't.

CUT TO:

FADE IN:

EXT. GIBSON AMPHITHEATRE - UNIVERSAL CITYWALK - EVENING

SUPER: SUNDAY, JUNE 8, 2008 - 5:30 P.M. PDT - THE INCREDIBLE HULK PREMIERE

A green carpet. Literally green. A twenty-foot practical HULK statue, sculpted from Amond's motion-capture scans, looms over the entrance with a fist raised. Fans pack CityWalk in purple shorts and green face paint. Universal's globe spins nearby.

AMOND BAKER (26) steps out of a car in a dark green velvet tux, his hand trembling slightly. Beside him is his mother, DENISE BAKER (50), in a gold church-best dress, clutching his arm like he might float away.

DENISE
Baby, they made a statue of you.

AMOND
That's not me, Mama. That's the Hulk.

DENISE
(squinting up at it)
It's got your nose.

An MTV NEWS CORRESPONDENT pushes a mic forward.

MTV CORRESPONDENT
Amond! Six weeks ago Iron Man made a hundred million dollars. Is there pressure?

AMOND
No pressure. Just the entire universe, a studio, my mom, and a statue with my nose.

Laughter from the press line. Further down the carpet: LIV TYLER (30) in emerald, TIM ROTH (47) grinning like a villain, TIM BLAKE NELSON (44), WILLIAM HURT (58) with quiet gravitas, and STAN LEE (85) waving with both hands.

Then a roar from the bleachers. MARC-ANTHONY steps onto the carpet, here as a guest, in a plain black suit, waving.

FANS
TONY! TONY! I AM IRON MAN!

He jogs straight past the cameras to Amond and grabs him in a hug.

MARC-ANTHONY
It's your night, Mond. I'm just here to clap.

AMOND
(whispering)
You've seen it, right? They showed you a cut?

MARC-ANTHONY
(perfectly innocent)
Me? No. Why would they show me YOUR movie?

Feige, passing behind them, makes a tiny choking sound into his coffee. Lenora Hayes (43), at his side, elbows him.

LENORA
(sotto)
Poker face.

FEIGE
(sotto)
I don't have a poker face. I have a cap.

CUT TO:

INT. GIBSON AMPHITHEATRE - AUDITORIUM - NIGHT

SUPER: SUNDAY, JUNE 8, 2008 - 7:20 P.M. PDT

Six thousand seats. Lights down. The film begins.

On screen: THE NEW MEXICO DESERT, 1990s. A gamma bomb test site. A TEENAGE RICK JONES drives a jeep past the warning signs on a dare. Bruce Banner (Amond) sees him from the bunker and RUNS out into the desert.

AMOND (ON SCREEN, AS BANNER)
Get in the trench! GET IN THE TRENCH!

He throws Rick into a ditch. The countdown hits zero. A blinding white flash engulfs him. The audience gasps.

Later, that first night: in a military infirmary, Banner's skin turns to stone. Massive, rough, and GRAY. A towering gray monster rips through the wall into the moonlight.

The Gibson Amphitheatre ERUPTS. Fans who know INCREDIBLE HULK #1 are screaming.

FAN IN THE BALCONY
GRAY HULK! GRAY HULK!

In the audience, Amond grabs his mother's hand. She's staring at the screen, horrified and proud.

DENISE
(whispering)
That's my baby?

AMOND
(whispering)
That's your baby, Mama.

Later. The climax: HARLEM. A real street, 125th Street, real fire hydrants exploding. The green HULK versus the ABOMINATION (Tim Roth), a scaly, practical-looking nightmare. They hurl a real bus. Real cars crumple. Under the Apollo Theater marquee, the Hulk takes a sledgehammer blow, roars, and grows visibly BIGGER.

AMOND (ON SCREEN, AS HULK)
HULK... STRONGEST... THERE IS!

The crowd goes wild. A row of Superhero Hype regulars in VIP passes (won in an online contest) leap to their feet: GARY (42), PRIYA (23), DARNELL (30), and TOMMY (20).

GARY
(shouting over the noise)
HE GOT BIGGER! HE GOT BIGGER WHEN HE GOT ANGRIER!
NO CEILING! THEY DID IT!

TOMMY
(in tears)
This is the greatest moment of my life!

CUT TO:

INT. GIBSON AMPHITHEATRE - AUDITORIUM - LATER

SUPER: SUNDAY, JUNE 8, 2008 - 9:12 P.M. PDT

The final shot: Bruce Banner, alone in a cabin in British Columbia, meditating. His eyes snap open. They glow GREEN. Smash to black. Huge applause. The credits begin to roll.

Amond leans back in his seat, exhausted, his mother sobbing into his shoulder. People in the aisles begin to stand.

AMOND
(to Marc, beside him)
That's it. That's the movie. Bro, I did it.

MARC-ANTHONY
(very calm)
You did, man. Hey. Sit down for a second.

AMOND
Why?

MARC-ANTHONY
Just... sit. Enjoy the credits. Respect the gaffers.

Amond gives him a funny look, but sits. Feige is at the side aisle again, gently waving people back to their seats.

FEIGE
(calling out)
Stick around, everybody!

The credits end. Black screen. Then: a dim, smoky BAR. General Ross sits alone, drinking, staring into his glass. The door opens. Footsteps. Someone sits on the stool next to him.

MARC-ANTHONY (ON SCREEN, AS TONY STARK)
Rough week, General? I hear your monster got loose in Harlem. Flattened a couple of city blocks. Ruined a perfectly good bus.

The camera pans up. It's TONY STARK. Sunglasses. Smirk.

The audience SCREAMS. A sound so loud it physically shakes the balcony.

WILLIAM HURT (ON SCREEN, AS ROSS)
Stark. I don't remember inviting you.

MARC-ANTHONY (ON SCREEN, AS TONY STARK)
Nobody ever does. That's never stopped me.

(beat, taking off his sunglasses)
What if I told you we're putting a team together?

WILLIAM HURT (ON SCREEN, AS ROSS)
(a long, wary look)
Who's "we"?

Tony just smiles. Black. The words: "THE INCREDIBLE HULK WILL RETURN."

Total pandemonium. People jumping on chairs. Stan Lee laughing so hard he has to be steadied by an usher. Priya is screaming "TEAM! TEAM! HE SAID TEAM!" over and over.

In the middle of all of it, AMOND turns slowly in his seat. He looks at Marc-Anthony. Marc-Anthony looks straight ahead at the screen, perfectly calm, eating a Red Vine.

AMOND
(very quietly)
...Were you in my movie?

MARC-ANTHONY
(chewing)
Huh?

AMOND
(louder)
WERE YOU IN MY MOVIE?

MARC-ANTHONY
I'm a very private person, Amond.

AMOND
(standing up, pointing, everyone around them watching)
YOU WERE IN MY MOVIE AND YOU DIDN'T TELL ME! YOU LET ME FIND OUT IN FRONT OF SIX THOUSAND PEOPLE! AND MY MOTHER!

DENISE
(still crying, delighted)
He looked so handsome in the bar, baby!

Feige appears at the end of the row, hands up in surrender, Leterrier hiding behind him.

FEIGE
Amond. Amond. We had to. You know why we had to.

AMOND
WHY?

LETERRIER
(peeking out from behind Feige)
The barista, Amond. The barista in Harlem.

Amond opens his mouth to argue. Closes it. He thinks about the barista. He sits back down slowly.

AMOND
(sulking, arms crossed)
...She asked me what I was filming. I panicked. I said "gray."

The entire row bursts out laughing. Even Amond can't stop himself. Marc-Anthony wraps an arm around his neck.

MARC-ANTHONY
I flew to New York at midnight on a Tuesday, shot it at two in the morning, and flew back before breakfast. I was dying to tell you every single day. I almost told you at the Super Bowl.

AMOND
Which Super Bowl?

MARC-ANTHONY
Both of them.

CUT TO:

EXT. UNIVERSAL STUDIOS BACKLOT - COURTHOUSE SQUARE - AFTERPARTY - NIGHT

SUPER: SUNDAY, JUNE 8, 2008 - 10:40 P.M. PDT

The famous BACK TO THE FUTURE courthouse square, lit with green lanterns. A DJ. Open bars. Waiters with trays of tiny burgers. The cast, crew and half of Hollywood mingle.

Amond stands near a fountain holding two sodas, scanning the crowd for Marc. He's stopped by a WOMAN in a simple black dress, leaning on the fountain with perfect posture.

HARMONY DIVINE (25). A dancer's body. A dancer's poise. A slight, nearly invisible favoring of one knee.

HARMONY
Congratulations, Dr. Banner.

AMOND
(startled)
Oh! Thank you. I'm... thank you. Sorry. You know me?

HARMONY
Everyone here knows you. You're the guy who yelled "you were in my movie" in front of six thousand people.

AMOND
(groaning)
That's going on YouTube, isn't it?

HARMONY
It's already on YouTube. My friend filmed it on her phone. It has eleven thousand views. In two hours.

AMOND
Great. Great. That's my legacy. Not the Hulk. "Man yells at best friend."

HARMONY
(laughing)
For what it's worth, I was the only person in my row who didn't scream at the end.

AMOND
You didn't like it?

HARMONY
I loved it. I'm a dancer. I was counting. The Hulk's movement when he grows under the Apollo marquee? It's eight counts, perfectly on the beat. Did you know you did that?

Amond stares at her. Nobody has ever said anything like that to him.

AMOND
...No.

HARMONY
You moved like a dancer who learned to be a monster. It was beautiful.

(holding out her hand)
Harmony Divine. I was on Broadway until my knee decided otherwise.

Amond tries to shake her hand while holding two sodas. He spills one entirely down the front of his green velvet tuxedo.

AMOND
(looking down at himself)
...Strongest there is.

Harmony laughs, a real, unguarded laugh. She grabs a stack of cocktail napkins from a passing waiter and starts dabbing his jacket.

HARMONY
Hold still, Dr. Banner. You're a disaster.

AMOND
(dazed, smiling)
Yeah. Yeah, I am.

Across the square, Marc-Anthony watches them with Tayia.

TAYIA
Is your best friend currently being dabbed by a stranger?

MARC-ANTHONY
(grinning)
I don't think she's going to be a stranger for very long.

CUT TO:

INT. CHILDREN'S HOSPITAL LOS ANGELES - FOURTH FLOOR PLAYROOM - SUNSET BOULEVARD - DAY

SUPER: TUESDAY, JUNE 10, 2008 - 2:00 P.M. PDT

A bright playroom full of kids in hospital gowns, some bald from chemotherapy, IV poles decorated with stickers. At the center, in a baseball cap, glasses and a hoodie, Marc-Anthony sits cross-legged on the floor

reading THE INCREDIBLE HULK #1 aloud, doing all the voices.

MARC-ANTHONY
(in a deep Hulk voice)
"Hulk... just want to be left alone!"

The kids giggle. A LITTLE GIRL, MAYA (7), with a headscarf, raises her hand.

MAYA
Are you Iron Man?

MARC-ANTHONY
(whispering)
Shh. I'm undercover. If anybody asks, I'm a substitute librarian.

The playroom door opens. A volunteer from a church group enters with a box of art supplies, in a simple cardigan and a baseball cap: ESTHER SMILLEY (25). The kids light up.

KIDS
MISS ESTHER!

ESTHER
(smiling)
Hi, everybody! Who wants to make paper crowns?

She kneels beside Marc-Anthony, setting down the box. They don't look at each other for a moment. Then they do.

ESTHER (CONT'D)
(sotto)
You're early.

MARC-ANTHONY
(sotto)
You're late.

ESTHER
The 10 freeway is a war crime.

Maya looks back and forth between them with the suspicious eyes of a seven-year-old.

MAYA
Are you two married?

Esther turns red. Marc-Anthony coughs.

MARC-ANTHONY
No. We're... colleagues.

MAYA
My mom and dad are colleagues too. They look at each other like that.

ESTHER
(quickly)
Paper crowns! Who wants gold?

EXT. CHILDREN'S HOSPITAL LOS ANGELES - PARKING STRUCTURE - CONTINUOUS

On the third level, a dark sedan parked in shadow. Inside, RUSS KESSLER (53) lowers a long-lens camera. Through the playroom window across the way, he has clear sight of Marc-Anthony and Esther, sitting on the floor with sick children, laughing.

Click. Click. Click.

He lowers the camera and looks at the display. Marc-Anthony helping Maya with a paper crown. Esther placing a crown on a bald little boy. The two of them, side by side, laughing at something.

Russ stares at the screen for a long time.

RUSS
(to himself, quietly)
...Aw, hell.

CUT TO:

MONTAGE - FRIDAY, JUNE 13, 2008: THE WORLD SEES IT

SUPER: FRIDAY, JUNE 13, 2008 - 12:01 A.M. TO 11:59 P.M. PDT

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "TONY STARK IS IN THE HULK MOVIE!!!!!! NOBODY KNEW!!!!!" (Page 1 of 287)

Gamma_Gamma_Hey (Jun 13, 12:04 AM)
I just walked out of the midnight show. NOBODY KNEW. No trailer. No TV spot. No leak. TONY STARK IS IN THE POST CREDITS. "We're putting a team together." I am DECEASED.

NoNerfsPlz (Jun 13, 12:07 AM)
I was at the premiere and I've been holding this in for FIVE DAYS. Marvel made us sign a pledge at the door. It was the hardest five days of my life. TONY. STARK. TEAM.

ShellHead1963 (Jun 13, 12:15 AM)
The gray Hulk on the first night. Rick Jones and the gamma bomb. The Hulk literally growing bigger as he gets angrier in the final fight. They promised "no ceiling" and they meant it. Two for two, Marvel. Apology #207.

WarMachineRox (Jun 13, 12:22 AM)
So the Hulk and Iron Man are in the same universe. The Wasp is in the same universe. Nick Fury. "A team." People, this isn't a theory anymore. It's a roster.

Repulsor_Ray (Jun 13, 12:40 AM)
the youtube video of amond finding out at the premiere is the funniest thing I've ever seen. "WERE YOU IN MY MOVIE" is my new ringtone

Mjolnir_Worthy (Jun 13, 1:05 AM)
So Marvel hid Marc-Anthony from AMOND. From his own BEST FRIEND. The level of secrecy at this company is unreal. What else are they hiding??

YOUTUBE.COM - "AMOND BAKER FINDS OUT MARC-ANTHONY WAS IN HIS MOVIE (HULK PREMIERE)" - uploaded by broadwaybaby_kel - 2,817,442 views

Top comment - greenslime96: "the barista amond." "...she asked me what i was filming. i panicked. i said gray." I'M CRYING

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE

amondbaker: to everyone asking: no, i did not know. they hid it from me. because of a barista. i will never trust again. also please go see my movie 12:30 AM Jun 13th from web

marcanthonyb: i've finally made a twitter. my first tweet is an apology to @amondbaker. i'm sorry i was in your movie bro. (i'm not sorry. it was awesome) 9:00 AM Jun 13th from web

hallhpriya: two marvel movies. two post credit scenes. two founding avengers. one universe. i need a cigarette and i don't smoke 9:14 AM Jun 13th from txt

FACEBOOK - GROUP: "MARVEL IS MAKING THE AVENGERS (CONFIRMED BY NICK FURY)" - 389,155 members

Wall post - Jordan K. (University of Michigan): Updated chart. IRON MAN: Tony meets Fury. HULK: Tony recruits for "a team." ANT-MAN: Hank and Janet, July 2009. THOR: ??? CAP: ??? AVENGERS: 2012. Every post-credits scene is a breadcrumb. Marvel is building the Avengers one movie at a time.

CUT TO:

DEADLINE HOLLYWOOD DAILY - SATURDAY, JUNE 14, 2008, 9:10 AM PT

HULK SMASHES: $25.6M FRIDAY; WEEKEND HEADED FOR HIGH $60Ms

Universal and Marvel are celebrating this morning. THE INCREDIBLE HULK is crushing expectations and will easily beat Ang Lee's 2003 HULK opening of $62.1M. CinemaScore is an "A-" and the Rotten Tomatoes score is a strong 87%. And that secret post-credits cameo? It's driving repeat viewings already. Moviegoers are buying second tickets just to see it again.

CUT TO:

INT. RUSS KESSLER'S CAR - PARKED OUTSIDE A DINER - CULVER CITY - DAY

SUPER: SATURDAY, JUNE 14, 2008 - 11:30 A.M. PDT

Russ sits in his car, a cup of coffee on the dash. The digital camera is in his lap, open to the hospital photos. Esther and Marc-Anthony with the kids. Laughing. Paper crowns.

He picks up his phone and dials. It rings.

DESMOND (V.O.)
Russ. Tell me something.

A long pause. Russ looks at the photos one more time.

RUSS
She goes to church on Sundays. She has choir on Wednesdays and Fridays. On Tuesdays she volunteers at Children's Hospital with a church group. She makes paper crowns with sick kids.

DESMOND (V.O.)
And?

Russ closes his eyes.

RUSS
And that's it, Mr. Smilley. Your daughter is exactly who you think she is. A good girl. Nothing to report.

DESMOND (V.O.)
(a long silence)
...And the ticket stub?

RUSS
Lots of people saw that movie, Mr. Smilley. A hundred million dollars' worth of people.

Another pause. Then a click. Desmond has hung up.

Russ sits for a moment. Then he ejects the memory card from the camera, looks at it, and puts it in his glove compartment, beneath the registration and an old map of the Valley.

RUSS (CONT'D)
(to himself)
Thirty years doing this. First time I ever lied to a client.

(sipping coffee)
Felt pretty good, actually.

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - FAMILY ROOM - VIEW PARK - DAY

SUPER: SUNDAY, JUNE 15, 2008 - 2:00 P.M. PDT - FATHER'S DAY

A Father's Day brunch. CORNELIUS SMILLEY (74) sits in his armchair watching cable news replays of Barack Obama's June 3 speech claiming the Democratic nomination. His eyes are wet.

CORNELIUS
(to no one, softly)
I marched in Montgomery for this. I raised money for that boycott with my own two hands. I never thought I'd live to see it.

Esther sits beside her grandfather and takes his hand. Desmond (50) watches from across the room, a gift box on his lap. Esther got him a set of cufflinks engraved "D.S."

DESMOND
Thank you, sweetheart. These are lovely.

ESTHER
Happy Father's Day, Daddy.

She smiles her perfect smile. He looks at her for a long moment, searching her face for something. He doesn't find it. Or he doesn't let himself.

DESMOND
You've been spending a lot of time at that hospital.

ESTHER
(without missing a beat)
The kids need us, Daddy. Pastor Williams says it's the most important ministry we have.

Desmond nods slowly. He puts the cufflinks back in their box. Across the room, Simone (28) catches Esther's eye. Simone's look says: careful.

CUT TO:

INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S HOUSE - BACK PORCH - LOS FELIZ - NIGHT

SUPER: SUNDAY, JUNE 15, 2008 - 8:30 P.M. PDT - FATHER'S DAY

Marc-Anthony and Amond sit on the porch steps with two beers, the city lights below. Inside, ROBERT BULLOCK (49) is losing to Grace (14) at Guitar Hero.

MARC-ANTHONY
Kevin called. Sixty-eight point nine million. Biggest Hulk opening ever. You beat Ang Lee by almost seven million.

AMOND
(shaking his head)
Sixty-eight point nine million. I used to eat cereal out of a mixing bowl because I couldn't afford bowls.

MARC-ANTHONY
You still eat cereal out of a mixing bowl.

AMOND
Now it's a choice. It's a lifestyle.

They laugh. A comfortable silence. Then Amond looks over.

AMOND (CONT'D)
Hey. Happy Father's Day to your dad. Tell him thanks for treating me like a son all these years.

MARC-ANTHONY
Tell him yourself. He's in there getting destroyed by a fourteen-year-old.

(beat, gently)
You call your dad?

AMOND
(looking at his beer)
Nah. I called my mom. She was both.

Marc-Anthony puts an arm around his shoulder. They sit with it for a moment.

AMOND (CONT'D)
(brightening, almost shy)
Hey. That girl from the afterparty. Harmony. I got her number.

MARC-ANTHONY
The one who dabbed you?

AMOND
She dabbed me with intent, Marc. She says I move like a dancer.

MARC-ANTHONY
You move like a man who spilled Sprite on velvet.

AMOND
That too.

(beat, then quieter, sly)
And speaking of girls. Who's "Pastor Williams"?

Marc-Anthony chokes on his beer.

AMOND (CONT'D)
Your phone was on the table at the premiere. It buzzed eleven times during my movie. Eleven. "Pastor Williams." That's the most texting pastor in the history of Christianity.

MARC-ANTHONY
Amond.

AMOND
Fine, fine. I'm not asking. I'm just saying. You hid a cameo from me for four months. I'm gonna find this out in four days.

MARC-ANTHONY
(smiling, looking out at the city)
You can't keep a secret, Mond.

AMOND
I can keep YOUR secrets. You know that.

Marc-Anthony looks at his best friend. A long beat. He almost says it.

MARC-ANTHONY
...Ask me again in a couple of years.

Amond raises his beer. They clink bottles under the Los Angeles sky.

FADE OUT.

MONDAY HEADLINES

SUPER: MONDAY, JUNE 16, 2008

VARIETY - MON JUNE 16, 2008

'HULK' SMASHES WITH $68.9M; MARVEL GOES 2-FOR-2

Biggest Hulk opening ever tops Ang Lee's 2003 debut; Baker's dual performance and a secret Stark cameo fuel strong word of mouth. "The Happening" opens a distant second.

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER - MON JUNE 16, 2008

MARVEL'S SECRET WEAPON: SECRECY

How the studio hid Marc-Anthony Bullock's post-credits cameo from trailer houses, Universal's marketing department, and even its own star. "We have a vault," says one insider. "And Kevin Feige has the only key."

ENTERTAINMENT WEEKLY - EW.COM

"Were You In My Movie?": The 30 Seconds That Made Amond Baker America's Favorite Superhero

The YouTube clip of Baker discovering his best friend's secret cameo has topped 2.8 million views. "It's the most relatable thing a movie star has ever done," says one fan.

IGN.COM - REVIEW

THE INCREDIBLE HULK: 9/10

"The gray Hulk. The gamma bomb. A Hulk that gets stronger as he gets angrier. Marvel is two for two on its promise to be faithful to the comics, and Amond Baker gives the most heartbreaking superhero performance since Christopher Reeve."

JET MAGAZINE - "PEOPLE ARE TALKING ABOUT" (Issue of June 30, 2008)

Two Black Superheroes, Two Number One Movies

Marc-Anthony Bullock and Amond Baker, best friends since childhood, now lead Marvel's universe. Plus: Who was the mystery woman spotted dabbing Baker's tuxedo at the premiere afterparty?

FADE OUT.

END OF CHAPTER SIX